Open-Source Projects to Reduce Children's Phone Addiction

Nov 3, 2026 · @improve the content and the design of this resume

Summary

No single project is a complete, mature child-protection solution. The strong ones are mostly self-control tools for adults, and the child-focused ones are small or young. The best result will likely come from combining them.

Best starting points

These five cover doomscrolling, porn, screen time, parent/child management and the home network.

Project	Focus	License	What it does	Main limitation
Curbox	Doomscrolling	GPL-3.0	Blocks Reels and Shorts, hides parts of an app's interface, and blocks specific URL paths	About 1.5k stars and the most established of the group, but built for self-control
Déchaîner	Porn	Apache-2.0	Uses Device Owner mode, forces family DNS, can block VPNs and factory resets, and classifies images on-device	Losing the recovery code can lock you out of changes for 48 hours

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TimeLimit	Screen time	Not checked	The child's device enforces limits and bans, while a sync server holds the family settings	One user's notes say it limits but doesn't track usage and that server self-hosting isn't supported; a reviewer says it blocks apps but not websites
OpenParental	Full parent/child system	MIT	Kotlin child app, Flutter parent app, NestJS backend, and alerts when protection is disabled	Only 8 stars
Fengard	Home network	Not checked	Adds firewall and DNS filtering plus screen-time controls to OpenWrt routers	Needs an OpenWrt router; updated in October 2026

Other useful projects

- **Reels and Shorts:** AwayDoomscrollin' keeps messages and search usable while covering or interrupting short-video feeds. FeurStagram is another option, with about 1k stars.
- **Porn blocklists:** hagezi, StevenBlack, and aegis-blocklist, which also targets VPNs, proxies, and self-harm content.
- **DNS filtering:** AdGuard Home has built-in parental controls and SafeSearch enforcement.
- **Device management:** Headwind MDM has an Apache-2.0 web console and Device Owner agent, with no device limit in the free edition. Kiosk mode and web filtering are paid features.

What to watch out for

- **OpenParental:** The copy I read says it's consent-first, but it also offers live screen viewing with no popup for the child. It includes decompiled FlashGet APKs as a reference too, which could be a legal risk, so check this before reusing any code.
- **Clones and spyware:** Lowpapin's README closely matches Scrolless's, so it looks like a rebrand. Avoid "parental" tools built on remote-access trojans like AhMyth, or marketed as spying apps, like SPYZIER.
- **Early-stage projects:** NoXXX has good ideas, but it has 1 star, was generated by AI, and has been tested on only one phone model. KidSafe's last release was in 2019, according to a forum post.
- **Effectiveness:** This review checked features, not whether these tools actually reduce addiction in children. Stars and READMEs don't prove that, and none of the apps were tested.

For Manara

The gap is a maintained, self-hosted parent console that combines Device Owner enforcement, Reels and Shorts blocking, and porn filtering.

Déchaîner and Headwind are the most useful code to study, and both are Apache-2.0. Curbox is the best model for granular blocking, but it's GPL-3.0, so reusing its code would generally require Manara to use a compatible GPL license. Decide on Manara's license before borrowing any of it.

Sources

- GitHub family-safety topic
- GitHub doomscrolling topic
- Awesome Parental Controls list
- timelimit-parent wiki
- TimeLimit notes
- TimeLimit on AlternativeTo
- Privacy Guides forum thread
- Headwind MDM open source overview
- Headwind MDM on G2